

to the casket, ceremony, disbursements (newspaper notifications, flowers, refreshments, booklets), burial, and plot. Totals vary wildly from state to state, of course. In Washington, D.C., the Department of Human Services offers burial assistance of \$850 for funerals that cost under \$2,000; at the other end of the spectrum are funerals that cost upward of \$30,000 because loved ones splurged on items like a stainless-steel casket. That certainly explains why “death care” is a \$17 billion industry. But here are a few ways to save money when emotions are riding as high as the price points.

First, plan ahead, pay in advance (if you can), and avoid the heartbreak and headache that funeral planning inevitably brings. Got the money for a deluxe oak casket with bronze handles? Knock yourself out if that’s what you really want. But I hope the knowledge that it’s a phenomenal waste of money follows you into the sweet hereafter (talk about Ghost Money!).

In a time of grief, the first skill that goes out the window is decision-making, so it’s always good to bring someone else, a trusted friend, with you when making arrangements. And remember, funeral directors are not counselors; they’re businesspeople first and foremost. The best ones are good at comforting with one hand while cashing the check with the other. You need someone reliable on your side to help sort through the hundreds of questions and decisions you have to make. Tell your friend your budget before you go in, and allow that person to help you stick to it.

If the funeral home says you must buy a casket from their company, find another funeral home. The markup on an average coffin is between 300 and 500 percent, so you can always do better on price. The biggest waste is always the coffin, something seen for a couple of days and buried underground for the rest of its existence. You might not be in the headspace to haggle, but you can ask someone less connected to the deceased to help you source a cheaper coffin. And don’t shy away from talking money and savings at a funeral. There is nothing more disrespectful to the dead than using the inheritance they intended as a proof of their love for you to line the pockets of strangers. I’ve made it clear to my family that if they waste a dime at my funeral, I’ll personally haunt them for the rest of their days.